later in his book, *The Chinese Betrayal*: ‘What Cariappa said at that time was indeed very discouraging and disappointing because I had also favoured military intervention in Tibet to save it from China.’

On 7 October 1950, the PLA crossed the Yangtse River at five points with the intention of isolating and capturing the Tibetan Army garrisoned at Chamdo. Commanded by General Liu Bocheng, the Second and Eighteenth Field Armies attacked Chamdo, the capital of the Kham region in Eastern Tibet.

Mullik was not the only one calling for a hard line to be taken against China’s expansionist policy. Home Minister Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, perhaps the only political leader who could challenge Nehru’s vice-like grip on the country, also advocated a showdown with China. So did Shyama Prasad Mukherjee (Minister for Industry and Supply) and a host of others. However, practical considerations, along with Nehru’s cultivated image of being a ‘man of peace’ perhaps resulted in India doing absolutely nothing to counter Chinese moves. Sardar Panikkar also advised Nehru not to oppose the Chinese annexation of Tibet. This resulted in a lot of hair-splitting about Tibet’s ‘sovereignty’ and China’s ‘suzerainty’ over Tibet. A few diplomatic notes were exchanged in which India expressed its concern and made the appropriate noises about respecting Tibetan autonomy and settling the issue in a non-violent manner. The Chinese, not quite believing their luck, nodded vigorously and promised to be good boys. The Chinese dragon then replaced the languid Tibetan snow lion on India’s northern border.

## SARDAR PATEL’S LETTER

At the meeting where General Cariappa had opposed Mullik’s suggestion that India consider armed intervention in the event of a Chinese invasion, the most notable missing personality was the home minister. In a letter dated 7 November 1950, Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, provided a masterly appreciation of the situation on India’s northern border after the Chinese takeover of Tibet:

> Their last telegram to us is an act of gross discourtesy not only in the summary way it disposes of our protest against the entry of Chinese forces into Tibet but also in the wild insinuation that our attitude is determined by foreign influences. *It looks as though it is not a friend speaking in that language but a potential enemy.* (Italics mine)

Sardar Patel’s assessment of the developing situation left nothing unsaid: with the arrival of Chinese forces at the very gates of India, the Himalayas